THE PAST WILL ALWAYS BE PERFECT



An exhibition of yesteryear film paraphernalia shows how things of beauty can be a joy forever







TREASURE TROVE
(clockwise from top left) Collector Dr Prakash Joshi, a poster of Sadhana and Kishore Kumar's *Man-Mauji* (1962), and film stills of actresses Sulochana, Purnima, Shubha Khote and Begum Para. Nearly 75 photographs of over 50 actresses from the black-and-white era will be on display at Piramal Art Gallery in Mumbai's National Centre for Performing Arts from September 10 to 13.





F

For the past 50 years, 76-year-old collector Dr Prakash Joshi has grown accustomed to brickbats. His treasured trove of possessions has sometimes even been dismissed as trash. He says, "Opposition is there all the time. Ask any collector's wife and she will tell you, '*Ghar ko kabad-khana bana diya hai*' [The house has been turned into a junkyard]." Fortunately for Joshi, his home in Mumbai's Walkeshwar has an attic. Here, he stores over 100 Hindi film posters, innumerable song booklets and thousands of film stills, dated from 1930 to the mid-70s.

A selection of these will be on display at the Piramal Art Gallery in Mumbai's National Centre for Performing Arts (NCPA) from September 10 to 13. Seeing that India is celebrating 75 years of its Independence this year, Joshi and gallery head Mukesh Parpiani have picked nearly 75 photographs of over 50 actresses from the black-and-white era.

Joshi avoids naming his favourite actress but what he does profess to is his fondness for Hindi film music. His collection of old Hindi film LPs is proof of that. The family's HMV radio, a "luxury" in the 1950s, and the show *Binaca Geetmala*, hosted by popular radio personality Ameen Sayani, both fuelled Joshi's passion. "It was a treat to the ears and a very important part of our lives," he says.

In the 1970s, when Joshi started his career as a doctor of integrated medicine, practising both ayurveda and allopathy, he'd set aside money to purchase Hindi film paraphernalia. His hunting grounds were the many shops nestled in the tiny lanes of Chor Bazaar and Bhendi Bazaar. "There was no buyer. *Hamare jaise pagle log hi interested the* [Only crazy people like me were interested]. You'd get a lot of material and it was dirt cheap." His ability to find rare LPs added to his repute. "My first love was always songs. *Mil gaya toh le lo* [If I'd find something, I'd get it]. I didn't have any other indulgences," he says. Over the years, Joshi's famed collection of records would bring many legendary music directors such as Anil Biswas, O.P. Nayyar, Salil Choudhary, Kalyanji (of Kalyanji-Anandji fame) to his house. Dr Joshi would also end up becoming their personal physician.

Joshi's penchant for Hindi film music ended in the mid-'70s, as musicals made way for action films. "1975 *ke baad melody hai kahaan?* [Where is the melody in songs after 1975?]," he asks. "I stopped listening to music ever since." As he sits down to pose with some of his favourite LPs—Lata Mangeshkar's records are particularly prized—Joshi, unlike other collectors, isn't too worried about what'll happen to his prized collection. His son, Dr Rahul Joshi, a homoeopath and a classical singer, has promised to preserve it for him. To see why this inheritance is a bounty, you might have to visit the Piramal Art Gallery this week. ■

-Suhani Singh

In his attic, Dr Joshi stores Hindi film posters, song booklets and film stills dated from 1930 to the mid-70s